and we are going to make sure that our armed forces exploit this strength optimally. I have thought of nominating the South Western Command, which is under raising, to be the test bed for IT and information warfare systems. Fighting in a synergized and joint manner calls for a joint doctrine and joint training, and greater level of inter-services cooperation. We in the defence forces today are in a state of transition from single-service entities to a synergized approach of jointmanship. The beginning was made by the creation of the Integrated Defence Staff with its headquarters at New Delhi, and the Strategic Forces Command and the Andaman and Nicobar Command, which are all joint structures. They have achieved a lot in their short span of existence. We still have a long way to go on the road to further integration in order to synergize our collective potential. Some of the areas which can be addressed without prejudice to respective domains include a common defence communications network, joint missile programme, exploitation of space by the three services, precision-guided munitions, combat potential evaluation model and, as far as possible, a common logistics infrastructure and human resources management strategy and training facilities.

The revolution in military affairs caused by battlefield transparency with the help of satellites, UAVs, radars and sensors, employment of hi-tech weapon systems and other force multipliers, is having an impact on our doctrine, concepts and structure for war fighting. In a modern battlefield success depends on tempo, lethality and survivability. The buzz word is manoeuvre and not attrition. Maximum firepower must be applied. All this calls for having a closer look at our doctrine, force structures, span of command and control and existing boundaries of our formations.

The other focus areas for us are assured and responsive logistics plans to support the operational plans, which are based on the principle, 'just enough and just when required'. Welfare measures to ensure the desired quality of life for all ranks at our military cantonments and stations remains one of our primary concerns. Importantly, we must give the highest priority to our schemes for healthcare and the welfare of our veterans, such as the Ex-Servicemen Contributory Health Scheme (ECHS). And finally, we need to ensure that physical fitness of all ranks and the importance of sports as a facilitator of building team spirit and camaraderie, continue to be given the highest importance.

For me, truthful reporting, loyalty and integrity are sacrosanct. I admire and appreciate frank and forthright subordinates, and do not want 'yes men'. The thrust of an argument or a dissenting note should be on the logic or rationale and pragmatism, rather than theory.